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Review

Collective memory and genetic social psychology: A necessary rediscovery in times of polycrisis

Charis Psaltis

Contemporary research on collective memory recognises the past's dynamic role in present conflicts and future possibilities. Yet, in our polycrisis era marked by resurgent authoritarianism and rising individualism, resulting in democratic backsliding and withdrawal from political participation correspondingly around the world, most current work on collective memory remains descriptive, treating groups as homogeneous units while leaving developmental mechanisms of memory transformation untheorized.

This article advances Genetic Social Psychology (GSP) as an interdisciplinary framework that addresses these gaps by examining how collective memory as social representations gets transformed through three types of social relationships: domination, submission, and co-operation. These relationship qualities shape not only *what* groups remember but also *how* memories transform (change) or not (continuity) across three timescales: microgenesis (through short social interaction or dialogue incidents), ontogenesis (lifespan), and sociogenesis (historical time).

Drawing on foundational texts (Piaget, Bartlett, and Moscovici), and more recent work by Gerard Duveen, we propose that revealing heterogeneity *within* each of the antagonistic groups in their representations of history and transformation of various positions in the representational field through intergroup contact and history teaching is key. Applied to divided Cyprus, this framework offers policy proposals towards conflict transformation and deepening democratic culture, resisting rising authoritarianism and domination/submission memory politics.

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Contemporary research recognises that collective memory shapes both present conflicts and future possibilities [1–3]. In our current polycrisis of democratic backsliding, distrust in political institutions and individualistic withdrawal from the commons leads to political apathy. At the same time resurgent authoritarianism of politicians, and undermining of UN and human rights institutions by great powers makes this apathy more worrisome. The need for reflective understanding of how groups remember, forget, and transform their past and participate in future making of more democratic processes has become urgent.

GSP proposed here rediscovers Piaget's social psychology [4–8] and Bartlett's work on memory [9] from another historical period of both rising authoritarianism (in central Europe) and rogue individualism (in the USA) at the eve of WW II. This is the proposal of social relations of co-operation (mutual respect and co-ordination of conflicting perspectives), expanded originally by Piaget [6] the social Genevans [10] and Duveen [11,12]. It charts a third way between deterministic sociological holism (where groups mechanically reproduce culture and suppress individual agency) and atomistic individualism where the individual dominates over the group through a malignant narcissistic and egocentric, power oriented tendency.

What was proposed by Gerard Duveen [13] as *Genetic Social Psychology* and expanded in recent years [13–20] as a proposal of an interdisciplinary framework integrating social and developmental psychology with history, education and history teaching aims to understand both individual and societal change across different timescales: microgenesis (through short social interaction or dialogue incidents), ontogenesis (lifespan), and sociogenesis (historical time).

Crucially, GSP reveals the heterogeneity within each of the antagonistic groups in their representations of history and collective memory, making visible the transformative role of socio-cognitive conflicts, participative and deliberative processes of mutual recognition of each partner in dialogue *within* and *across* groups. This enables progressive change away from rigid exclusive victimhood narratives that are supported by relationships of domination or submission and victimisation.

Collective memory as social representations

Despite the existence of a voluminous body of work on collective memory as social representations [21–23,25] key ideas are still underdeveloped. In his oft-quoted definition, Moscovici proposes social representations are a "system of values, ideas and practices" [24 p. xiii]. In this definition the "values" part has been under-theorized. There are important insights in both Piaget's and Bartlett's work on how values could be conceptualised as organising principles of social representations as an outgrowth of social relations or social relational tendencies correspondingly [6,9].

Social relationship forms in Bartlett and Piaget

Unlike Durkheimian sociology that reifies culture, community, and groups, Bartlett [9] studied individuals *within* groups. He argues that there are three fundamental and universal "social relationship tendencies" of domination, submission, and primitive comradeship [25, p. 92]. When there is asymmetry of power and status in a social relationship, the higher-status individual or group takes on the dominant or assertive tendency, while the lower-status actor takes on the submissive tendency. 'Primitive comradeship' is expressed in symmetrical social relationships. These distinctions matter because they shape both what is remembered (matter) and how it is remembered (manner). In other words, these relationships profoundly shape remembering, though they have not clearly been articulated in the literature (beyond the classics).

Those in the submissive tendency tend to superficial compliance (rote learning, rigid and superficial forms of recounting past events). On the contrary, in more symmetrical social relationships, social influence moves freely from both parties without force from either.

Bartlett [9] also talks about two other fundamental social tendencies: *conservation* (stability) and *construction* (change). These are value orientations in need of further integration in the theory of social representations with more recent theorising about historical consciousness [26] and human value orientations [27]. The conserving tendency is past-oriented and supports the continuation of institutions, whilst the construction tendency is future-oriented and supports the emergence of new ones. In fact, this theme of the conditions for the emergence of novelty is central in the whole work of Bartlett, and there are striking similarities between his thinking and Jean Piaget's social psychology of the development of morality [6], where Piaget is proposing the distinction between social relations of constraint and social relations of co-operation.

In Piaget, relations of *constraint* are asymmetrical in status or power, characterised by unilateral respect. Their prototype is the child-adult relationship. In contrast, relations of *co-operation* are characterised by mutual respect and their prototype is relations between peers. Whilst relations of constraint become an obstacle to both moral and intellectual development for a child who finds itself in the submissive or passive position, relations of co-operation facilitate de-centering, the coordination of different perspectives, reflection, new constructive solutions, a shift from heteronomous to autonomous morality, and the transition from pre-operational to operational thinking.

Moscovici later drew on both Piaget [28] and Bartlett [9] for the formation of both his *Social Representations Theory* and his *Genetic Model of Social Influence*. As he admits himself [29], Bartlett's notion of conventionalisation helped him formulate his process of *objectification*, but *anchoring* [30] is also clearly adapted from Bartlett's ideas. In Moscovici's dual process Genetic Model of Social influence [31], the parallels with Bartlett's and Piaget's work are also striking: he likens majority influence with processes of conformity and compliance leading to more superficial, direct, and public influence, whereas minority influence is indirect, delayed, and private, leading to innovation and novelty in the societal arena.

Communication styles and types of social representations

Moscovici's seminal work on how psychoanalysis spread in French society in the late fifties [30] distinguished between three communication styles based on power symmetry: diffusion (symmetrical, creating individual opinions in liberal press), propagation (asymmetrical with Catholic church as source, forming shared and selective attitudes) and propaganda (asymmetrical with Communist party as source, creating shared stereotypes).

Relevant distinctions between social representations are also offered by Moscovici [32] when he is proposing the existence of hegemonic (shared by all members of a highly structured group without them having been produced by the group; they are uniform and coercive), polemical (generated in the course of intergroup conflict or controversy and society as a whole does not share them) and emancipated representations (the outgrowth of the circulation of knowledge and ideas belonging to subgroups that are in more or less close contact so that each subgroup creates and shares its own version).

Links between communication styles and types of social representations are nevertheless not clearly articulated by Moscovici. More recently, Moscovici [33] proposed a simpler distinction between social representations. *Social representations based on beliefs* whose kernel consists of beliefs that are generally more homogenous, affective, impermeable to experience or contradiction, that leave little scope for individual variations, and *social*

representations based on knowledge, *which are more* fluid, pragmatic, amenable to the proof of success or failure, and leave a certain latitude to language, experience, and even to the critical faculties of individuals [33, p. 136].

For Duveen [34, p. 547] this distinction offered more promise but was still in need of development as it did "not yet include any clear discussion of the functional aspects of these representations, of the modalities through which they circulate or are communicated, or the ways in which they serve to structure different types of social groups, or may be structured by different types of social relations".

Genetic social psychology: sociogenesis, ontogenesis and microgenesis

From the perspective of GSP [13], the structure of any particular social representation is a construction and thus the outcome of some developmental process. When Duveen proposes the term Genetic Social Psychology [13] he is proposing three types of transformations associated with social representations: Sociogenesis, Ontogenesis and Microgenesis. The aim of Genetic Social Psychology is to render intelligible the articulation of these three processes of change.

Microgenesis [12] is the motor of both ontogenetic and sociogenetic change and is located in social interaction where individuals meet, talk and discuss and resolve differences of perspective.

Ontogenesis is the process through which children acquire access to the social representations of their community and processes of internalisation reflected in the reconstruction of both social identities and social representations during the life span.

Finally, sociogenesis is the process most clearly related to Bartlett's theorising on the diffusion of an idea through cultural contact between groups.

In our joint work with Gerard Duveen at the turn of the 21st century, we explored the links between microgenetic and ontogenetic processes in 6–7 year olds who worked in dyads for the solution of two Piagetian tasks (the conservation of liquids and the village/spatial perspective-taking task) [35–38]. In this work, the depth, novelty, and stability in time of recall and learning largely depended on the symmetrical or asymmetrical form of the conversation types, suggesting that the distinction between relations of constraint and co-operation in Piaget was meaningful in influencing both the matter and manner of what was learned and remembered but it also revealed that conflict of various asymmetries (status and knowledge) could create conditions of productive symmetry and novelty.

Expanding genetic social psychology to the study of collective memory and the role of history teaching

More recently, the study of the articulation of microgenesis, ontogenesis, and sociogenesis of social representations was extended to the study of intergroup conflict between Greek Cypriots and Turkish Cypriots in Cyprus [39–46] and their representations of the past, present, and future of the unresolved Cyprus problem. The opening of the checkpoints in the UN patrolled buffer zone between the geographically divided island for 30 years in 2003 created the prototypical conditions of what Bartlett described as cultural contact and the sociogenesis of new representations of each community for the other community, collective memory, and the Cyprus problem itself. It also allowed more nuanced understandings of sociogenetic processes by comparing age, period and cohort effects in changing levels of prejudice and distrust.

Within each community, we identified three significant structures as social representations in the representational field [46] related to political identities of domination, submission, and co-operation [20]. The ethnonationalist and communitarian positions are backed up by institutions of power (e.g, Turkey and the non-recognised state in the TC community, church and state in the GC community) characteristic of high levels of realistic and symbolic threats and low intergroup contact. They also relate to conformity and traditional values with high Right Wing Authoritarianism (RWA) (as a position of submission or victimisation) orachievement, hedonism and power values with high Social Dominance Orientation (SDO) (as a position of domination) [20]. The dominating position wants to promote a hegemonic representation in the ingroup through education, history teaching [39–42] and propaganda [40,44] but works in tandem with a submissive and exclusive victimisation narrative in relation to regional powers and the enemy on the basis of a threat narrative. The ethnonationalist and communitarian representations are *polemic* in relation to the master narrative of the conflict of the other community and the outgroup.

On the contrary, the third position, the pro-reconciliation one, is supported by high levels of co-operative intergroup contact between the two communities, which relates to universal and self determination values and, as such, has become *emancipated* from the aforementioned centres of power. The study of the transformation of one type of representation to the other in historical time is one of the major aims of the study of sociogenesis in Genetic Social Psychology in Cyprus [20].

Co-operative collective memory functions as alternative representations and counter-narratives related to ideological currents of leftist internationalism and identity

politics of Cypriotism (a shared superordinate identification as Cypriot that includes both GCs and TCs) [41]. Here, good quality intergroup contact [47–49] works as the motor of microgenetic change that could change the ontogenetic social relational tendency of an individual from constraint to co-operation and, at scale, facilitate the diffusion of a memory of the past intergroup relationships away from antagonism, victimisation, and one-sided perspectives into more co-operative forms. At the same time, what we termed *transformative history teaching* [43,44], aiming at reflecting on master narratives and promoting multiperspectivity, can offer children powerful reconstructions of the past that would complexify the history of the conflict in ways that resist propaganda and this in Cyprus was achieved through the work of bi-communal NGOs like the Association for Historical Dialogue and Research (AHDR) and shared spaces like the Home for Co-operation in the UN patrolled Buffer Zone of Nicosia.

Conclusion

Why is this framework a necessary rediscovery in times of polycrisis? First, as authoritarianism resurges globally, exclusive past victimisation narratives, securitisation and the spectre of various enemies will be weaponised more and more to strengthen both domination and submission relational tendencies and legitimise democratic backsliding. Second, the way out of polycrisis demands future oriented, creative and transformative thinking [3]. However, domination and submission/victimisation narratives are past-fixated on traditional forms of historical consciousness. In Cyprus, our data shows that uncritical internalisation of master narratives of conflict undermines the prospect of a compromise solution on the basis of the UN supported Bizonal Bicommunal Federation. Third, emerging threats like AI mediated collective memory come from both the direction of rogue Machiavellian individualism (domination) and conspiracy theories (submission/victimisation) [50–53]. In fact the AI revolution is reconfiguring all relationships between the *subject-object-other* epistemological triad of GSP with AI not being only an "object" of representation but also replacing human "Other" with an AI "Other" in our social interactions amenable to any algorithmic manipulation.

On all fronts, attention to the social relational conditions and their emergence in echo chambers of constraint at scale call for urgent regulation of both the social media and the AI technology to be aligned with co-operative relationships and de-centering from ethnocentric perspectives. GSP calls for transformative pathways from domination/submission to co-operation that can be materialised by intergroup contact, multiperspective and transformative ways of history teaching through reflection on master narratives and their social function, which is what Bartlett called "turning round upon one's own schemata [9, p.206]. Last, but not least, innovative uses of AI [54] for deliberative participation of citizen's in peace negotiations and effective countering of individualist withdrawal from the commons becomes absolutely necessary.

Credit author statement

Charis Psaltis was responsible for the research article conception, planning and writing.

Data availability

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Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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** of outstanding interest

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Further information on references of particular interest

1. * In this empirical article the authors report that exclusive victimhood was related to geopolitical attitudes in Hungary and Serbia. In the study Serbian (N = 630) and Hungarian (N = 471) adult national samples stratified by gender, age, political orientation, and place of residence. They found that exclusive victimhood predicted higher support for a geopolitical shift from the West (i.e., EU and US) to the East (i.e., Russia and China) via Euroscepticism in both samples adding to other recent research that shows the links between past-present-future orientations of the national group. Importantly for the framework of Genetic Social Psychology exclusive victimization was related to ingroup pride which shows that the submissive and dominant positions could paradoxically support each other. Piaget would actually not differentiate these two positions and place both under the banner of asymmetrical relations of constraint.

3. * In this influential article the authors propose that social psychological research, whether it is intended or not, contributes to change in the societies and cultures we live in, and thus it cannot be seen as a discipline that is a passive bystander of world-making. On the contrary, by embracing social psychology of and for world-making and facing up to the contemporary societal challenges upon which our collective future depends will make social psychology more relevant. Importantly, research findings like Milgram's or the Stanford Prison Experiment show that social psychology is a historical science in that it changes society, making past findings difficult to replicate as people's understanding of power evolves.

13. ** This is one of the rare editions that bring together a social and developmental perspective on the ontogenesis of social representations. In the introduction of the volume Gerard Duveen and Barabara Lloyd propose Genetic Social Psychology and discuss microgenesis, ontogenesis and sociogenesis. In the same volume there is a commentary by Serge Moscovici that discusses social and developmental psychology as two sides of a single coin.

20. ** This book is comprised by two parts. In the first part Charis Psaltis presents the latest integration of *Genetic Social Psychology* linking the significant structures of domination, submission and cooperation with historical consciousness, threats, contact and values. In the second part renowned social and cultural psychologists are invited by Brady Wagoner to comment on the proposal and related it to their own work.

44. * This chapter is part of an edited volume as one of the outputs of the project MAKINGHISTORIES where various social and cultural psychologists, history teachers and historians from various countries discuss the role that dialogue can play in history education and the socio-cultural, psychological, and digital dimensions of dialogic practice to promote research into historical thinking, historical consciousness, and critical thinking in educational settings. The Cyprus chapter cited here was co-authored by Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot colleagues involved in formal and informal initiatives to promote multiperspective history teaching in divided Cyprus.

54. * This paper describes the use of AI facilitated online deliberation platform named the Habermas machine. In Cyprus we also tested the platform Remesh AI. In this paper by Tessler et al., group opinion statements generated by the Habermas Machine were consistently preferred by group members over those written by human mediators and received higher ratings from external judges for quality, clarity, informativeness, and perceived fairness. AI-mediated deliberation also reduced division within groups, with participants' reported stances converging toward a common position on the issue after deliberation.